Elias (Eliya) of Nisibis — Chronography / Opus Chronologicum (author, 975–1046)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Elias of Nisibis (975–1046), of whom this record gives little more than his dates. His *Chronography* is the only East-Syriac universal chronicle of the Eusebian type, and its distinction is the honesty of its method: his chronological tables name his source for each entry. The record calls that a model of honest citation a millennium early, and the dedication honours a chronicler who showed his working.

The author's own terms

In Elias's *Chronography*, the *canons* are the chronological tables that follow his lists; they give dates in both the Seleucid and the Hijra reckonings, set out in columns, and they name his source for each entry.

The story

Elias of Nisibis — also given as Eliya of Nisibis — lived from 975 to 1046. His *Chronography*, also known by its Latin title, *Opus Chronologicum*, is described in the record as the only East-Syriac universal chronicle of the Eusebian type: a history of the whole known past, arranged by years, in the tradition associated with Eusebius.

What distinguishes Elias is not only the range of his chronicle but the honesty of its method. The canons — the chronological tables that follow his lists — give dates in both the Seleucid and the Hijra reckonings, set out in columns, and they name his source for each entry. A reader can see, entry by entry, where Elias took his information from. The record calls this a model of honest citation a millennium early, and it is the quality that makes the work a prime source for church records as well as a chronicle in its own right.

In plain terms, Elias did not simply hand down dates. He showed his working. For a reader interested in the history of the Church of the East — its patriarchs, its rulers, and the order of its years — that habit of naming sources turns a table of dates into evidence that can be checked.

Yet for all its order and care, the work has no English form in the record gathered here. Latin readers have editions more than a century old. A French translation of part exists. English readers, on the searches recorded, have reference entries and citations only.

The work and what survives

Part I consists of chronographical lists: lists of patriarchs, kings, and rulers, and an annotated list of the catholicoi of the Church of the East — the heads of that church, with notes attached to the names. The canons that follow give Seleucid and Hijra dates in columns, naming the source for each entry.

The Syriac text was edited by E. W. Brooks as CSCO 62, published in 1910 and reprinted in 1962, with Brooks's Latin translation as CSCO 63. Part II was edited by Chabot in 1909, with Chabot's Latin translation in 1910. A French translation of part exists, through Delaporte.

The CSCO text and Latin of 1909–1910 are in the public domain by date.

Its English fortunes

No English translation found after research.

Searches returned reference entries and citations only, and no English edition. That finding sits beside real partial provision in other languages: the Latin translations of Brooks and Chabot, complete with their editions, and Delaporte's French translation of a part.

What completing it would take

The natural order is to translate the annalistic second part first. That is the narrative, source-citing portion — the part told year by year, with Elias's sources named — working from the Syriac and Latin of Brooks and Chabot.

The tabular Part I, with its lists, is a separate, formatting-heavy second volume. Tables of patriarchs, kings, rulers, and catholicoi have to be set accurately as tables, and the record treats that as a distinct piece of work rather than folding it into the first.

In scale, the dossier places Elias as smaller and more completable than either Michael the Syrian or Bar Hebraeus, the larger Syriac names considered elsewhere in this collection.

Sources

- https://gedsh.bethmardutho.org/Historiography-Syriac
- https://gedsh.bethmardutho.org/Chronicles-Syriac
- https://pocketbook.es/downloadable/download/sample/sample_id/541498/?bookId=NDgxNzUx